

Collectio Avellana 419

Ep. 4 — The emperors on the ordination of Siricius: one acclamation elects and rejects (24 Feb. 385; CSEL 35.1, pp. 47–48)

A LETTER OF CONGRATULATION ON THE ORDINATION OF POPE SIRICIUS.

Greetings, Pinianus, most dear to us. That the people of the Eternal City rejoice in concord and choose the best priest we perceive to belong to the very constitution of the Roman people, and we give thanks that this comes to pass in our own times. Accordingly, since they have so willed the devout Siricius, a bishop of holiness, to preside over the priesthood, that they crushed the reprobate Ursinus with their acclamations, let the said bishop remain [in office] to our joy, Pinianus most dear and most delightful; for it is a great proof of innocence and probity that in one and the same acclamation he himself is elected and the others rejected. Given on the sixth day before the Kalends of March, at Milan.

The collective title of the Boniface/Eulalius dossier (CSEL 35.1, p. 59)

CONCERNING THE THINGS DONE BETWEEN BONIFACE AND EULALIUS, WHEN BOTH OF THEM, AFTER THE DEATH OF POPE ZOSIMUS, USURPED THE EPISCOPATE OF THE ROMAN CITY BY THE INTRIGUE OF STRIFE.

Ep. 15 — Honorius to Symmachus: the first verdict, for Eulalius (3 Jan. 419; pp. 60–61)

A COPY OF THE SACRED LETTER.

When all the proceedings had been reviewed, it became clear from your Sublimity's praiseworthy report that in the ordination of the venerable priesthood the insolence of a few sought to assail the ancient tranquillity. For whereas, after the departure of the venerable Zosimus, a harmonious multitude had cried out with common judgment concerning the merit of Eulalius as the one to be substituted in due order, and the successor's confirmation preserved in his favour all that the rule of catholic discipline requires, we greatly wonder that there arose certain persons who, in contempt of the [proper] solemnity, hastened to the ordination of another. Against whose deed it would rightly behove our clemency to rise up in chastisement, were it not that on this ground we judged them to belong to pardon: that, quickly perceiving their own lapse, they fell back

upon the recourse of entreaty, asking that they be forgiven for that of which — having suffered violence — they had complained. Let your Sublimity therefore know, by our clemency's present authority, that our wish and our zeal are agreed in favour of Eulalius, bishop of the sacred law, upon whom a competent number of ordainers, the solemnity of the lawful time, and the fitness of place have rightly conferred the summit of the venerable name. But since it is established that all these things were lacking to Boniface, we judge that our verdict has been awaited to no purpose, since those who had presumed appear, by the entreaties they submitted, to have condemned the bishop they themselves had made. And so by an absolute command we decree that, that extraordinary presumption being set aside, Boniface be at once forbidden the city, its access interdicted: it will befit his modesty that, complying with the heavenly ordinances, he withdraw of his own accord; but should he resist too obstinately, we order him to be expelled against his will. The authors of the plebeian sedition, together with their associates, your Sublimity — Symmachus, most dear and most loving father — will resolve to have detained, and will resolve that due punishment be exacted upon them, so that a thing rashly presumed may not pass unpunished. In which matter it has pleased our clemency that Aphrodisius, a most distinguished man, tribune and notary, be dispatched, so that in his presence the things we have determined may be carried out the more speedily, to the end that the people's tranquillity be vexed by no disturbance, and that the pacified whole body may venerate him whom — according to the ancient custom — the observed mysteries of the sacred law have received. Given on the third day before the Nones of January, at Ravenna.

Ep. 17 — The Roman presbyters' petition for Boniface (Jan. 419; pp. 63–65)

A COPY OF THE PRESBYTERS' PETITION ON BEHALF OF BONIFACE.

We beseech your Clemency, most pious and most merciful emperors Honorius and Theodosius, ever Augusti. After the departure of the holy pope Zosimus of the catholic church of the city of Rome, as custom would have it be done and as the very discipline of religion dictated, we, a good number of priests, came together into one [assembly], to deliberate by common judgment about appointing a successor. But because the archdeacon Eulalius — with almost all the entrances barred, and the obsequies of the supreme priest impiously despised — had beset the Lateran church with [his] deacons and a very few presbyters and a throng of the disturbed populace, on the next day we hastened to the same church, where it had earlier been arranged by all, and there, the counsel having been shared with the Christian people, we elected him whom God commanded. For the venerable Boniface — an aged presbyter, most learned in the law and approved for his good character, and (what adorned him the more) unwilling — we took to ourselves by the acclamation of the whole people and the consensus of the better [men] of the city, [as one] consecrated by the order of divine institution; for, with more or less seventy presbyters subscribing, and nine bishops of various provinces standing by, it is established that the benediction was celebrated at the fitting time, and that thereafter all was fulfilled that the solemnity required. But when the aforesaid Eulalius — who had earlier been formally warned, on the authority of many, through three of our fellow-priests, not to take upon himself anything rashly against the awareness of the greater clergy — having circumvented a very few presbyters, having ill-treated and consigned to various custody those who had come with letters to forbid him, and having produced, among others, the bishop of Ostia, who is known to have been summoned when nearly dead (for the old man's sickness testifies that he was dragged there unwilling) — had, with the order of religion left unguarded, burst by intrigue into a place not owed to him:

he began unbecomingly to defend his deed through men ignorant of discipline and unacquainted with religion, thinking that by human disturbances he could confound the divine verdict. And since it is established that your Clemency was deceived by a lying report, so that you ratified — I know not what — to the injury of the divine judgment (for whatever the election of men so great confirms is divine), we beseech your Piety to order the earlier ordinances revoked, and that Eulalius, who crept into a place not his own, ought to be brought, with his abettors, to the court of your Perpetuity. For we declare that the holy pope Boniface will be present with our fellow-priests. For, with individual presbyters left behind at the several title-churches, all will attend who may declare their will — that is, the judgment of God. Let your Clemency also command all whom the case binds to be present, and that those who are unwilling, and do not suffer themselves to be brought, be even cast out of the city. You will find, once the inner examination begins to be set in motion, that [the deed] not only is abhorrent to the divine laws but also may be displeasing to the human ones; and so, having obtained this, we render to your eternal rule the greatest and most abundant thanks.

Ep. 20 — Honorius to the synod: partisans may not judge; with the deadlock rubric (Feb.–Mar. 419; pp. 67–68)

A COPY OF THE SACRED LETTER TO THE SYNOD.

Our Clemency has indeed, in the present [instance], committed everything to your Beatitude by a fitting arrangement, that — all things being held in suspense — you might determine by your own judgment what ought to be observed for the tranquillity of the people. We recall, too, that this above all was enjoined by us, as equity demanded: that those bishops who are known to have taken part in the ordinations [of either party], or afterwards to have subscribed to them, should not — without injury to themselves and with their reverence remaining intact — sit as judges, nor be able to give any testimony, lest they should seem not so much about to bring forth a new verdict as to be upholding a past deed. These, therefore, as we said above, will have to abstain from that adjudication. Let your Beatitude know that this too must likewise be observed: that no prejudgment has been contrived against either party by what had earlier been made clear as decreed by us. For since the commands quickly dispatched have, for the people's tranquillity, been withdrawn by our Piety's subsequent authority, neither party will be able from this either to claim anything or to have anything to fear. Attending, therefore, to the judgment of God, which in such a case is manifestly seated together with you, it befits you, when all things have been examined, to observe that which — by the infusion of the heavenly Spirit — may keep the reverence of the Christian law entire.

THIS SYNOD, DISSENTING AMONG ITSELF, COULD NOT BRING THE PRESENT CASE TO A CONCLUSION. WHENCE THE VENERABLE EMPEROR HONORIUS JUDGED THAT THIS BUSINESS MUST BE DEFERRED TO A GREATER COUNCIL, AND MEANWHILE — ON ACCOUNT OF THE DAYS OF HOLY EASTER WHICH WERE AT HAND — ORDERED BOTH, NAMELY BONIFACE AND EULALIUS, TO DEPART FROM THE CITY, AND ORDERED THE BISHOP OF SPOLETO, ACHILLEUS BY NAME, TO CELEBRATE THE SACRED MYSTERIES, INTIMATING THIS SAME THING TO SYMMACHUS, PREFECT OF THE CITY, BY HIS OWN LETTERS:

Ep. 21 — Honorius to Symmachus: a neutral bishop for Easter (15 Mar. 419; pp. 68–69)

Of great deliberations the judgment ought not to be hasty, nor are those things to be brought forth rashly which are enacted to be kept in perpetuity. Often, in the matter of the bishops of the Eternal City, the inquiry has been shaken through the altercation of the parties under the scrutiny of the priests; but that nothing hasty be brought forth by speed of judgment, this has settled upon our Clemency's decision: that — since the nearness of the holy days required a bishop's presence, and since in the most sacred city it was not lawful to celebrate the days of Easter, above all (*praesentim*, i.e. *praesertim*), without a priest — therefore, Symmachus, most dear and most loving father, let your illustrious Magnificence know that we have chosen Achilles, one whom it was established to be a stranger to the favour of the parties, to fulfil the mysteries of the sacred observance. But when the festal days are over, we shall deal, by riper counsel and in accordance with the judgment of the priests, with what ought to be observed. We admonish you assuredly to summon the chief men of the districts and to provide for public discipline and tranquillity; to them let you order the injunctions of our decrees to be disclosed, so that no one, of course, may dare to stir up any tumult or sedition. And if anyone, by insane persuasion, should rouse [such a thing], let them understand that punishment will be exacted not only upon those caught in the disturbance, but upon the leaders of the districts as well. For we know that public tranquillity is easily kept, if the cravings and the incitements of the instigators cease.

Ep. 24 — Honorius's edict to the Roman people (15 Mar. 419; pp. 70–71)

AN EDICT OF THE SAME EMPEROR TO THE PEOPLE.

Judging the care of the faith to be of the greatest moment, most excellent Quirites, we have thought that nothing hasty or premature should be brought forth. For in a matter of religion we hold that only those things should be decided which can be approved by all without error or censure of the verdict. And so, since in the inquiry concerning the bishops who had been set up in the city the ambiguity of the contention hung unresolved under the priests' judgment, and — with fresh causes continually arising — no end could be put to the contending zeal, and our deliberation long hung upon various matters, we have determined that the whole business be deferred to a future inquiry, to a fuller council with a full number of priests, so that the case, weighed on every side, might, when the days of Easter are past, receive the conclusion which equity and religion demanded. At the same time, because nothing could be settled about the [permanent] priest, we have chosen one temporarily to celebrate the reverend mysteries on the sacred days, so that for you, Quirites, the solemn office of a priest might be at hand, to the honour of the sacred city. Wherefore, imitating our patience, receive with calm minds what we urge for the public peace: let the observance of the holy days pass by with due tranquillity, let no sedition disturb the public quiet, let no partisan favour show itself toward anyone who might be marked out for it. For it befits you, with your feelings held in suspense, to reserve all things intact for our judgment, and not with a kind of frenzy but with due uprightness to await rather than to demand a priest. But if, following depraved instigators, you should choose disorders and tumults rather than quiet and moderation, you will show whom you favour; and a peril to [your] safety — to which you drive us — will threaten

not only you but also your ringleaders, to whose counsels you cling. For he is not worthy of pardon who cannot be restrained from wickedness by the warnings of our humanity. Given on the Ides of March.

Ep. 26 — Honorius to the African bishops: the judgment of many (20 Mar. 419; p. 72)

LIKEWISE, [A LETTER] OF THE SAME EMPEROR TO THE AFRICAN BISHOPS.

Our Serenity desires to have a well-weighted judgment in all matters, but especially in those which pertain to venerable religion. We believe that the contention which has arisen concerning the priesthood of the Eternal City has by now been reported even across the seas. Since it could not be settled by a few, the judgment of many is accordingly established to be necessary. Wherefore let your Holiness — [you] whom goodness of life and the teaching of the law commend — deign, all excuses cut away, to hasten to the city of Spoleto by the day of the Ides of June, so that what truth and the norm of religion shall have dictated may be judged by a [common] verdict, God alike breathing upon the minds of all, lest the priesthood of the apostolic see be longer deferred.

Ep. 33 — Honorius to Symmachus: Boniface confirmed (3 Apr. 419; pp. 79–80)

A COPY OF THE SACRED LETTER TO SYMMACHUS, PREFECT OF THE CITY.

Our Serenity has acted with especial moderation, that presumption might find no room. For the inquiry was deferred to the judgment of the venerable priests precisely for this, that whatever religion, whatever truth demanded, a tranquil adjudication might decide it without any disturbance. But the text of the report has shown that, by the usurpation of Eulalius, many things were unlawfully committed against the sentence of the venerable synod; who, by his very presence furnishing the people an occasion of frenzy, wished all to perish that our moderation preserves. For whereas, by our ordinance and by the sentence of the bishops — of whom the greater multitude had gathered in synod — and also by the consent of the parties and their express profession, it had been settled that this should be so: that whoever should have entered the city to incite the people should know himself to be specially condemned — [Eulalius,] forgetful of himself, proved by his present deed what sort of beginning it seemed to have had. Since, therefore, it is established that this man was rightly driven from the city after so many misdeeds — to which the judgment both of our Clemency and of the bishops appears to have ruled that he ought not to approach — let your Sublimity know, Symmachus most dear and most loving father, that we have determined that Boniface, a venerable man and bishop — to whose governance we have rightly judged our authority ought to be joined — ought to enter the city, so that under his governance the reverence of the religious law may be fulfilled with its accustomed moderation. Given on the third day before the Nones of April; received on the sixth day before the Ides of April.

Ep. 34 — Symmachus's report on Boniface's peaceful entry (Apr. 419; pp. 80–81)

A COPY OF THE REPORT OF SYMMACHUS, PREFECT OF THE CITY, CONCERNING THE ENTRY OF POPE BONIFACE, [ADDRESSED] TO THE EMPEROR NAMED ABOVE.

Whatever things are established with God as their author are deservedly brought forth by the divine judgment of your Piety. For lately, when the sacred authority of your Clemency had issued to me, your servant, whereby — all ambiguity removed — your Majesty strengthened the priesthood of the venerable Boniface, bishop, the things that were commanded proved so welcome to all that both the most ample order (the Senate) and the Roman people approved them, my lords emperors Honorius and Theodosius, pious, fortunate, renowned, ever-triumphant Augusti. For when the heavenly ordinances had been read out by me to the people and, with edicts posted everywhere according to custom, made public, so great was the favour and joy of the whole city that all, with fitting congratulation, testified that both religion had been restored to them and the security of tranquillity granted. And so, after an interval of two days, the aforesaid venerable bishop entered the city with all the people coming out to meet him, just as your Serenity had ordained; nor were the dutiful services of my office in any way wanting. Nor does any dissension of the peoples now remain, since all have acquiesced in the divine judgment and in the will of your Majesty. With partisan zeal therefore ceasing, all have begun to be of one mind — that which, admonished by the command of God, you decreed — and by the acclamations which are appended below the Roman plebs has testified the causes of its joy, and does not cease to give thanks to your Serenity day by day; whose provident care, even as it guards the peace of the world, so has it restored tranquillity to the city and concord to the people.

Ep. 36 — Largus to Aurelius of Carthage: the contest has ceased (Apr. 419; p. 82)

A LETTER OF LARGUS THE PROCONSUL TO AURELIUS, BISHOP OF CARTHAGE.

To his lord and honourable father Aurelius the bishop, Largus. Concerning the merit of the priest whom God has proved fit for his own, the contest has ceased. The imperial clemency has therefore confirmed the holy and venerable Boniface as bishop of the city of Rome — for whose election it lately commanded your Holiness to be summoned, as the sacred addresses, brought forth with reverence, attest. It behoves you, therefore, speedily to revisit your peoples and churches, [you] for whom the necessity of a sea-voyage has been taken away. AND IN ANOTHER HAND: May divine favour keep you unharmed for many years, my lord and father, deservedly honourable.

Ep. 37 — Honorius to Boniface: the statute for a doubtful double election (419/420; pp. 83–84)

A LETTER OF THE EMPEROR HONORIUS TO BONIFACE, BISHOP OF ROME, IN WHICH HE ENACTS THAT, IF EVER TWO BISHOPS SHOULD AGAIN BE ORDAINED, BOTH ARE TO BE EXPELLED FROM THE CITY.

Victor Honorius, renowned, ever-triumphant Augustus, to the holy and venerable Boniface, pope of the Eternal City. We have received your Beatitude's letter with the congratulation due to our reverence, rendering the greatest thanks to almighty God that we have learned your holiness restored, after a long indisposition, to the health we wished for; and therefore, as the venerable men return, we set the seal upon our joy by the attestation of these sacred rescripts, and we ask that your apostolate may deign, in daily prayers, to expend its zeal and its vow upon our welfare and our empire. And know that this has well pleased our Piety: that your Holiness is anxious over the disturbance of the churches or of the people — a disturbance which, that it may not by any means come to pass, our Clemency has judged to have been sufficiently provided against. Finally, with your Beatitude proclaiming it, we wish this to come to the knowledge of all the clergy: that if perchance anything — which we do not wish — should by the human lot befall your religious person, all should know that they must desist from ambitious canvassings; and that if perchance two should, against right order, in the rashness of contending, be ordained, none of these shall be a priest at all, but he alone shall remain in the apostolic see whom, out of the number of the clergy, by a fresh ordination, the divine judgment and the consensus of the whole body shall have chosen. Whence this is to be observed: that all keep a tranquil mind and peaceful spirits in accordance with our Serenity's admonition, and attempt nothing by seditious conspiracies, since it is certain that partisan zeal will profit no party.